

# Module 2: Entrepreneurial Inclusion

## 02-01 Introduction

### Transcript:

In this module, we'll continue with some of the ideas from last week around contextualizing innovation and entrepreneurship. The major theme of this module and the next will be that at the heart of innovation and entrepreneurship, they are all about people. Everyone has the capability to become an entrepreneur and to lead innovation. However, there are systemic constraints that we need to be aware of. Some of these barriers are experienced more by people of particular demographic backgrounds. Our goals in this module include recognizing systemic restraints to participation in innovation and entrepreneurship, but also exploring ways of mitigating those barriers to participation. We will also start to explore sources of innovation and explain how diverse teams often create better and more innovative solutions.

We will have three guest speakers for this module. The first speaker is Dr. Jennifer Jennings from the Alberta School of Business. Professor Jennings is a tier 1 Canada Research Chair in Entrepreneurship, Gender and Family Business. She has edited two books and published over 30 research articles in this area. She will share some insights from several decades of work on women's entrepreneurship, including how entrepreneurship as a phenomenon is often gendered, leading to different constraints for women participating in business ventures. This research is helpful for identifying not only barriers, but also ways of mitigating them.

Our second speaker is Meghann Law, the co-founder of the Edmonton-based store Re:Plenish. She will share her story, articulating some of Professor Jennings' insights in practice, and also highlighting the importance of community in starting a business.

Then we have Jessica Carlson, Executive Director, Economic and Trade Policy at the Government of Alberta. She will cover some of the challenges and opportunities for women entrepreneurs as well as intersectional entrepreneurs in Alberta.

This module will cover a number of different anecdotes as well as broader research insights. I'd like you to pay attention to the question of what challenges you think all entrepreneurs face, and the more specific societal and cultural constraints that women entrepreneurs face. For example, all entrepreneurs face what organizational scholars call the "liability of newness". This was originally coined by researcher A.L. Stinchcombe more than 50 years ago to describe organizational mortality. This was focused on the precarious existence of nascent organizations, focusing on how newness of a company was linked to a high risk of failing.

Later work on organizational ecology further explored this topic of the struggle with emergent organizations. As Yang and Aldrich wrote in 2017, "social activities will shape the fate of emergent organizations, in addition to what founders assemble as their initial endowments". But this also points to how entrepreneurial activity is itself embedded in widely held societal beliefs about typical characteristics associated with men and women, as well as the appropriate behaviours and roles for each sex. This means that gendered beliefs impact gendered founders.

But our purpose here is not to simply lament the challenges that women entrepreneurs face; rather, identifying them upfront in our course is a basis for confronting these cultural and societal constraints. Social change requires collective action at the systemic level and there are current efforts actively working on this. Our goal together in this class should be to better understand women entrepreneurs, in addition to the broader phenomenon. We should as well appreciate the perseverance and ingenuity of women entrepreneurs presently finding ways to mitigate these issues. In particular, look at the importance of community and family, and how profit maximization

is not the only possible approach to entrepreneurship.

I've asked you to read the first chapter from our textbook, entitled "Zuckerberg's Shade and the Specter of Gates". This is good introductory material and will provide you with a nice backdrop for our discussions.